What does it mean to talk about the return of politics to Myanmar? How are politics differentiated from "the political" promised in this chapter's title? And what is the relationship of each to conflict?

A convenient place to start on these questions may be with the distinction Chantal Mouffe (2005, p. 9) makes between politics and the political, where the former concerns "the set of practices and institutions through which an order is created" for the organisation of human existence, while the latter refers to the "dimension of antagonism" that is constitutive of human relations (see also Wolin 2004, p. 40).[2] For Mouffe, the political does not reside in elections or in a ruling organisation or set of institutions, as Max Weber (1968, pp. 54-55) would have it. Those arrangements are the stuff of politics. The political is more like a condition in which we disagree but also together try to figure out how to decide on stuff that matters without attempting to kill one another. It is a manner of relating to difference, as Dipesh Chakrabarty (2002, p. 140) has written, in which "difference is neither reified nor erased but negotiated".[3] In sum, the political is concerned with rivalry among collectivities recognizing one another as substantive equals who communicate hostility dialogically through fundamentally nonviolent means.

When the political is denied, conflict turns violent. And violence, which is nothing other than a means to some ends, is basically a nonpolitical response to conflict (Arendt 2006, p. 163, again contra Weber, as discussed in Kalyvas 2008, p. 30). This is not to say that violence might not have a possible utility in certain types of political action (Finlay 2009, p. 27), but it has no political meaning of its own (Arendt 1969, p. 51). In general, violence is what occupies the space from which the political has departed. In particular, physical violence subsumes the political in the moment of its performance.[4] Where words fail us, and all that remains is mute bloodshed and brutality, the political dissipates. The *non*political, then, is concerned with enmity between collectivities kept apart and relating to one another as (merely human) enemies who communicate hostility monologically and through fundamentally violent means.

Violent conflict stands apart from and threatens political conflict not only because of its distinctive nonpolitical qualities but also because it has a tendency to reproduce itself. Where conflict is habitually addressed through violence, political habits are eroded and eventually lost. Once that point is reached, as in Myanmar during recent decades, special attention needs to be directed to the political, so as to better articulate and understand